

Arguments in Response to Multiple Texts: Screen Time

Layering Reading, Writing, and Thinking

Researchers and academics often refer to academic writing as a “conversation.” Students start by reading and understanding various voices and positions about an issue, and then find their own place in the ongoing conversation.

This short unit uses the [layering process](#) to guide students as they consider multiple perspectives. In this resource, students will read and respond to four different layered activities centered on the topic of Screen Time. Through layered reading, reflective writing, and critical thinking, students work through their own changing opinions and ultimately develop a claim.

Layer #1: Becoming Aware

1. Start with a quickwrite (2 minutes) about the topic: “What are your thoughts about [Screen Time](#)?”

This first writing is to acknowledge that we usually come to an idea with a gut claim, feeling, or belief.

2. Watch a video: [Screen Time Rules For Kids](#) | Let's Talk | NPR

As you watch, jot down any interesting details or facts that you hear or see in the video.

(This writing can be done directly below the initial quickwrite. Continue to keep your writing in your notebook.)

3. Write informally for a few minutes and continue with your quickwrite. What do you want to know more about? Where do you stand on this issue right now?

Try out some sentence templates. Pick one ... or a couple!

- According to the NPR video ... (detail from the video)
- This makes me think/wonder ...
- In my experience ...
- I agree/disagree because ...
- At first I thought _____, but now ...

Layer #2: Expanding the Conversation

1. Read “[How much screen time is OK for my kid\(s\)?](#)” from Common Sense Media. As you read, pay attention to the main claim of the article as well as the presented facts and details.

2. Add to your writing with new information from the text.

Possible templates:

- As the article states ...
- Now I am thinking/wondering ...
- Just as I was thinking earlier ...

Layer #3: Add Another Text

1. Read “[American Academy of Pediatrics Updates Guidance on School Safety Amid Pandemic](#),” a news release from AAP that was published on March 17, 2020 at the beginning of the pandemic.

2. Add to your writing with new information from the text.

Layer #4: Add a Final Text

1. Read “[Let 2021 Be The Year You Let Go of Screen Time Guilt](#)” by Alex Hazlett, Romper.com, January 4, 2021.

2. Add to your writing with new information from the text.

Final Step

After thinking and layer-writing through this set of texts, students are ready to write their own claim about the topic.

Extensions

After working through several texts, students will have gathered a lot of textual evidence and written their own commentary. When this writing is pieced together, students have a rough draft start of an essay where they trace their thinking toward their own claim. This first draft can be developed further as students make choices about an organizational structure, develop their reasoning, and even add more source material.

Texts for this short unit could be easily changed by topic or reading level.